



An individual spends an average of 3 hours per day on social media. Do you know how these platforms affect our lives?



Socialising is an integral part of our lives. It helps us empathise with people around us and learn new things about the world. Socialising lets us share our experiences with others and enables us to listen to theirs.

A group of friends, family, relatives, or a community can be called a social network.

Social networking

Our social life revolves around networking with our peers, teachers, parents, relatives, and people around us. This is how humans learnt to create community circles and societies.

Interest groups, libraries, book clubs, social events like festivals are familiar modes of physical interaction. These are ways through which we bond closely with other humans. People who get together may or may not have common goals or interests.



Social networking on the internet

The internet lets us access any information from anywhere in the world. Emails and messengers gave people an opportunity to connect with others in seconds. This new wave of online networking accelerated the world's progress. This allowed people to connect with loved ones, colleagues, clients, and even strangers from any location.



In the early 2000s, the internet exploded with social websites where people could create their personal profiles. They were able to add their interests, skills, photos, and personal collections. Social websites encouraged people to connect with friends, family, and other like-minded people, to share ideas, chat, and socialise online.

The real boom of social networking arose when Facebook launched in 2004. This social network was created by Mark Zuckerberg and it became an instant hit among the public. By 2010, it had 500 million users and 2.6 billion users by 2021.

Facebook was followed by Twitter, Reddit, Instagram, TikTok, and every other site we see now!

Byte

sixdegrees.com launched in 1997 and is known as the first ever social networking site that let its users add friends and connect with new people.

Activity

■ Search for the theory of six degrees of separation.

Exercise

■ Tick mark ☒ the correct answer

1 Which of these is or was a social media networking application?

- | | | | |
|------------|--------------------------|------------|--------------------------|
| a. Uber | ☐ | b. Twitter | ☐ |
| c. Youtube | ☐ | d. GitHub | ☐ |

2 Which of these is the earliest chat messenger tool?

- | | | | |
|--------------------|--------------------------|------------|--------------------------|
| a. AOL | ☐ | b. GTalk | ☐ |
| c. Yahoo Messenger | ☐ | d. Google+ | ☐ |

Traditional and modern sources of information

With the world rapidly transitioning into the digital space, traditional modes of sharing information have transformed into new, modern models. Traditionally, information was shared via televisions, newspapers, magazines, and radios. Today, it is shared via e-mails, e-newsletters, streaming services, and online video sharing platforms.



Traditional sources of information



Modern sources of information

A large part of the world's population is on social media. It does not require a monthly or yearly subscription and most applications or websites are free for all to use. This convinces more people to create profiles and share content on them. Content could be of any genre, including education, art, and entertainment.

The problem arises when some people start using social media platforms for malicious activities. These activities include:

- Hacking someone's social media account
- Creating fake profiles to pose as someone else
- Spreading inaccurate information
- Disrespecting an individual, group, religion, or culture



Currently, social media is facing another massive issue: data security. Recent investigations tell us that an individual's data can be stolen from their personal profile. This creates a sensitive situation where data theft may result in an individual's personal information spreading on the internet. Information could include their contact details, address, payment details, and more.

Every time we discuss something online with a friend, watch a game, or check-in at a hotel, social media is able to track what exactly we are doing. They have meticulously studied the working of our brain and how it reacts to information. They use this to keep users hooked onto their website.

Social media addiction is a real problem and has results similar to substance addiction if its usage isn't controlled.

Pros and cons of social media:

Pros of Social Media	Cons of Social Media
Cost-effective tool for business marketing	Depression and anxiety
Excellent research tool	Creates a skewed self-image
Instantly connects users with the right people and interest groups	Devoid of emotional connection
Real-time feedback	Easy for people to be hurtful to others
Campaigns supporting a variety of causes	Adds to laziness
Marketing tool for individual skills	Causes distractions from productive activities

Note:

Write a 500 words document about: How the Egyptian Revolution started on Facebook in 2011.

Healthy Practices

Apart from regular safety measures that come with surfing the internet, we need to keep some more in mind while using social media.

1. Do not flood your profile with every minute detail about your life. Keep it to a minimum.
2. Do not 'like' unnecessary pages, this provides the website more data points to track you.
3. Be courteous and kind while communicating with friends online.
4. Do not accept friend or message requests from random strangers.
5. Do not waste your time engaging in arguments with strangers online.
6. Do not share suspicious links or controversial posts without verification.
7. Limit your usage to only 30 to 60 minutes per day.
8. If you're spending too much time on social media, deactivate or uninstall the application, especially during exam season.
9. Make healthy use of social media by joining active interest groups like drama, dance, sports, etc.
10. Cyberbullying is a serious offence. In case you have faced any form of harassment online, reach out to your parents, teachers, or a trusted adult immediately.

Byte

Fine Print: An everyday phrase to refer to terms and conditions before signing up or using a service.

Activity

 **Make a presentation titled "What is Cyberbullying and how to deal with it".**

Outline:

- What is Cyberbullying?
- What actions constitute cyberbullying?
- What measures should you take, if you are a victim of any of these actions?
- What consequences are you likely to face if you are caught cyberbullying?

Exercise

 Tick mark ☒ the correct answer

- 3** Which of the following cannot be done on social media?
- a. Awareness of the world and connectivity ☐
 - b. Networking with like-minded people ☐
 - c. Sharing skills and talent ☐
 - d. Ordering food ☐
- 4** Which of these measures will you take to safeguard your account on social media?
- a. Create a predictable password ☐
 - b. Not share too much of personal information ☐
 - c. Accept random friend and message requests ☐
 - d. Clear browser history and cache ☐
- 5** Which of these activities are prohibited on social media?
- a. Spreading hate speech or racial slurs ☐
 - b. Adding friends and known people ☐
 - c. Giving likes and comments ☐
 - d. Sharing your interests and images ☐

Socialising has been a crucial concept for human interaction. Modern times have introduced different social media platforms for people to connect with each other from all over the world. But along with being a boon, social media comes with its dangers. It calls for cautionary measures since the internet can be a medium for malicious activities.

Social networks have made it easier for us to interact with people across the globe. However, we should always be mindful of the harm social media platforms can cause.



Tech Flash

- **Social media** : An interactive platform that lets users interact with other people through posts, likes, comments, and messages.
- **Privacy** : In a digital space, privacy is the right to own one's information and the right to share it or keep it private.